CONFOEDERATIO,
RESEARCH DIVISION (CRD).

POPULATION OF THE FORMER RUSSIAN EMPIRE DURING THE CIVIL WAR

War, Famine, Border Changes and Recovery Across the 48 Pre-War Provinces

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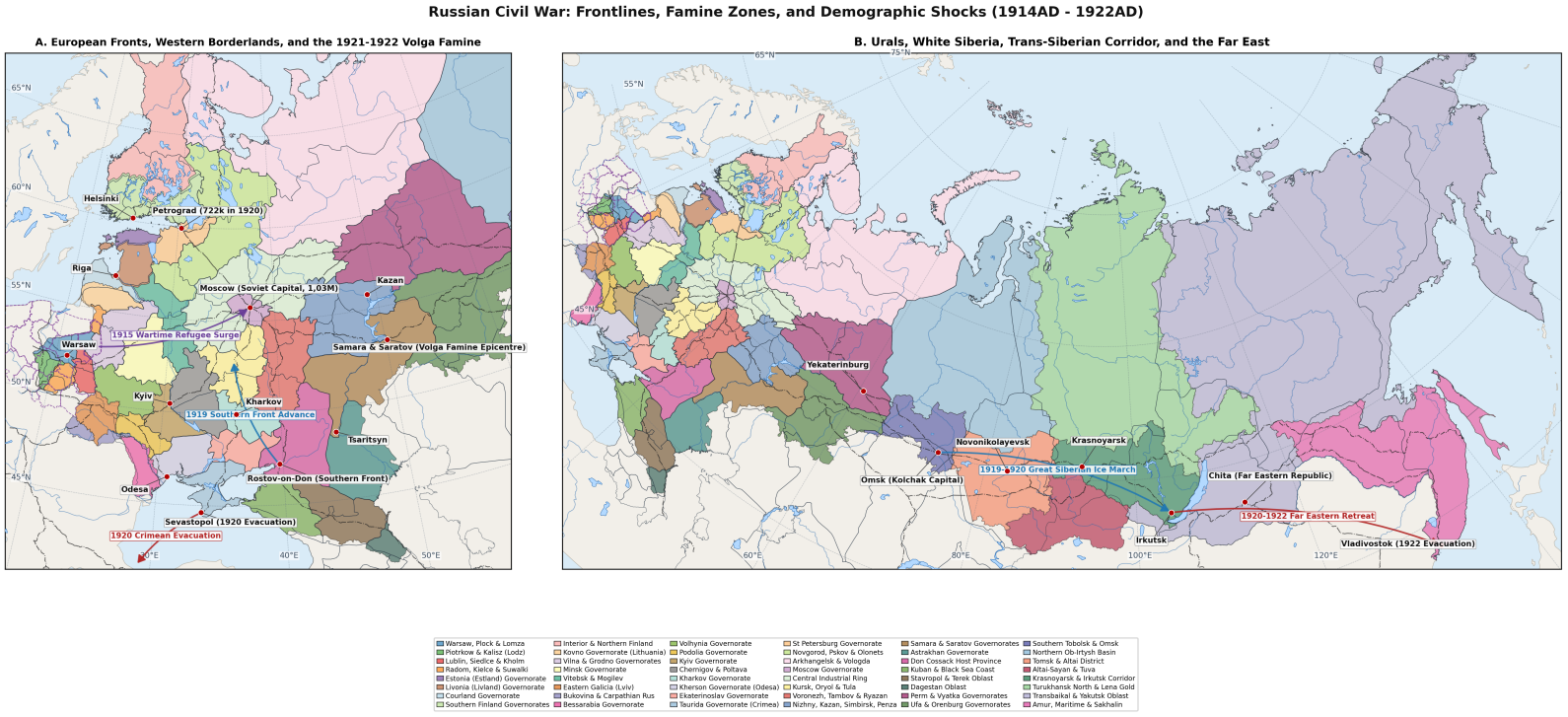


Figure 1. The 48 pre-war provinces of the Russian Empire and Eastern Galicia, showing the 1920-1921 western treaty borders, the 1921-1922 Volga-Ural famine belt and principal urban centres.

Abstract

The First World War and the Russian Civil War brought the long nineteenth-century growth of the Russian Empire's population to an abrupt halt. Across the 48 pre-war provinces (18,61M km2, excluding Central Asia and the Southern Caucasus), the population edged down from 167,94M in 1914 to 165,38M in 1917, and then plunged through five years of civil war, urban flight, typhus and the 1921-1922 Volga-Ural famine to a low of 148,66M in 1922. Even so, the total loss of 8M to 10,5M excess military, epidemic and famine deaths, roughly 2M emigrants and a birth deficit of 12M to 14M did no more than set the 1926 population back to its 1914 level: four years of recovery under the New Economic Policy (*NEP*) and peacetime growth in the new western states brought the total back to 167,78M by December 1926 [1][2][3][4]. Leaving aside the two former Habsburg provinces of Galicia and Bukovina-Subcarpathia (Regions 14-15) and Finland (Regions 8-9), the 44 Russian imperial provinces fell from 155,41M in 1914 to 135,85M in 1922 before recovering to 153,69M in 1926.

Background

Following the population of the Russian Civil War from the 1914 pre-war baseline to 1926 is difficult because the Russian Empire broke apart between 1917 and 1921 into the Soviet republics and seven Central and Eastern European states [1][5][6][7]. Figures limited to post-1921 Soviet territory mix actual war and famine deaths with border losses and two-way refugee movements [8][9][10][11]. Keeping the 48 pre-war provinces fixed (including Congress Poland, the Baltic provinces, Finland, Lithuania, Bessarabia and the neighbouring Carpatho-Galician borderlands) makes it possible to follow the whole crisis from 1914 to 1922 in one view: First World War mobilisation, the 1915 Great Retreat (*biezenstwo*), the 1918 Brest-Litovsk treaty and border wars, fighting between Red, White and peasant armies, the emptying of the cities under War Communism, typhus and Spanish influenza, and the 1921-1922 famine on the Volga, in the Urals and in southern Ukraine. By December 1926, peace treaties had placed 37,84M people from these provinces inside the new European states and shifted 4,94M through internal Kazakh, Tuvan and western district adjustments, leaving 125M inside the 1926 census territory of the RSFSR, Ukraine and Belarus [12].

Methodology

Eight main census and statistical sources provide the figures for the 48 regions. For the pre-war baseline and First World War refugee movements, the 1914 statistical yearbooks and the 1917 agricultural and town censuses record provincial populations and the movement of 6M to 7M western refugees (*bezhentsy*) and soldiers into central Russian, Ukrainian and Belarusian towns [8][13][14][15]. At the height of the Civil War, the 28 August 1920 Russian census, directed by Pavel Popov at the Central Statistical Administration (*TsSU RSFSR*), counted the accessible European and Siberian provinces when urban flight under War Communism was at its worst [16][17].

In the northwest, Finnish official statistics (SVT VI, 1917-1926) and the War Victims in Finland (1914-1922) register give parish counts across Finland's eight provinces (Regions 8-9), the December 1920 census (3,36M legal population; 3,11M present) and death records from the 1918 Finnish Civil War [18][19][20]. Across the Gulf of Finland, the early censuses of independent Latvia (1920 and 1925), Estonia (1922) and Lithuania (1923) measure wartime evacuation losses and post-war refugee returns in Estland, Livland, Courland, Latgale and Kovno (Regions 5-7, 10 and 13) [21][22][23][24][25].

Along the western frontier, the 30 September 1921 Polish census (GUS) covered Congress Poland (Regions 1-4), the eastern borderlands (*Kresy Wschodnie*) in Vilna, Grodno, western Minsk and western Volhynia (Regions 11-12 and 17) and Eastern Galicia (Region 14), supplemented by the 1919 Polish eastern administration (*ZCZW*) count [26][27][28]. Farther south, the Czechoslovak census of 15 February 1921 and Romanian counts (1919-1926) cover Subcarpathian Rus (604,6k in 1921), Bukovina (Region 15) and Bessarabia (Region 16) [29][30][31].

Inside the Soviet republics, the 15 March 1923 urban census recorded the early NEP recovery across 1,93k cities and towns just after the 1921-1922 famine [32][33]. Finally, the First All-Union Census of 17 December 1926 and the 1926-1927 Polar Census, published in 56 volumes under Vasily Mikhailovsky and Osip Kvitkin, provide complete rural and urban figures across all Soviet republics, autonomous republics and northern territories [5][12].

Results

Regional Trends and the 1926 Borders

Table 1 gives the population series from 1914 to 1926 for all 48 pre-war provinces, grouped into three broad areas: the Western Borderlands (Regions 1-16, 1,02M km2), Ukraine and Novorossiya (Regions 17-24, 541,9k km2) and European Russia, the North Caucasus, the Urals, Siberia and the Far East (Regions 25-48, 17,04M km2). Figure 2 shows the regional trends and combined totals.

Province / Region	1914	1917	1918	1919	1920	1921	1922	1924	1926
1. Warsaw, Plock & Lomza Governorates	5,05M	4,42M	4,35M	4,42M	4,48M	4,61M	4,74M	4,92M	5,11M
2. Piotrkow & Kalisz Governorates	3,32M	2,95M	2,89M	2,94M	2,98M	3,06M	3,15M	3,28M	3,41M
3. Lublin & Siedlce Governorates	2,68M	2,08M	2,12M	2,18M	2,21M	2,32M	2,43M	2,56M	2,68M
4. Radom, Kielce & Suwalki Governorates	2,6M	2,18M	2,16M	2,21M	2,25M	2,33M	2,41M	2,52M	2,63M
5. Estland Governorate	505k	515k	485k	465k	460k	470k	480k	490k	498k
6. Livland Governorate	1,56M	1,42M	1,28M	1,19M	1,15M	1,19M	1,23M	1,28M	1,33M
7. Courland Governorate	800k	380k	410k	440k	480k	520k	555k	590k	615k
8. Southern Finland Governorates	1,84M	1,89M	1,84M	1,85M	1,88M	1,91M	1,94M	2M	2,06M
9. Interior & Northern Finland Governorates	1,4M	1,43M	1,41M	1,42M	1,43M	1,45M	1,47M	1,51M	1,55M
10. Kovno Governorate	1,84M	1,32M	1,38M	1,43M	1,47M	1,53M	1,59M	1,67M	1,74M
11. Vilna & Grodno Governorates	3,94M	2,88M	2,84M	2,79M	2,76M	2,88M	3,01M	3,19M	3,36M
12. Minsk Governorate & Pripyat Polesia	3,04M	2,89M	2,82M	2,74M	2,68M	2,72M	2,79M	2,94M	3,11M
13. Vitebsk & Mogilev Governorates	4,02M	3,86M	3,78M	3,68M	3,61M	3,64M	3,71M	3,89M	4,08M

14. Austro-Hungarian Eastern Galicia	5,02M	4,45M	4,38M	4,31M	4,29M	4,39M	4,49M	4,68M	4,86M
15. Bukovina & Subcarpathian Rus	1,63M	1,5M	1,48M	1,46M	1,45M	1,48M	1,51M	1,57M	1,63M
16. Bessarabia Governorate	2,66M	2,62M	2,58M	2,54M	2,52M	2,55M	2,59M	2,68M	2,77M
Subtotal Regs 1-16: Western Borderlands	41,91M	36,78M	36,2M	36,06M	36,09M	37,04M	38,08M	39,76M	41,43M
17. Volhynia Governorate	4,12M	3,68M	3,61M	3,49M	3,41M	3,46M	3,54M	3,72M	3,91M
18. Podolia Governorate	3,98M	3,82M	3,75M	3,61M	3,51M	3,53M	3,58M	3,74M	3,92M
19. Kyiv Governorate	4,78M	4,84M	4,74M	4,56M	4,42M	4,44M	4,51M	4,74M	4,98M
20. Little Russian Governorates	6,65M	6,72M	6,64M	6,51M	6,38M	6,31M	6,26M	6,51M	6,81M
21. Kharkov Governorate	3,44M	3,51M	3,46M	3,38M	3,29M	3,23M	3,19M	3,36M	3,54M
22. Kherson Governorate	3,75M	3,78M	3,69M	3,56M	3,41M	3,21M	2,98M	3,21M	3,48M
23. Ekaterinoslav Governorate	3,45M	3,58M	3,46M	3,29M	3,14M	2,98M	2,81M	3,12M	3,46M
24. Taurida Governorate	2,06M	2,08M	2,02M	1,94M	1,79M	1,59M	1,41M	1,59M	1,79M
Subtotal Regs 17-24: Ukraine & Novorossiya	32,23M	32,01M	31,37M	30,34M	29,35M	28,75M	28,28M	29,99M	31,89M
25. Saint Petersburg Governorate	3,15M	3,38M	2,62M	2,08M	1,69M	1,79M	1,96M	2,31M	2,69M
26. Novgorod, Pskov & Olonets Governorates	3,58M	3,68M	3,58M	3,46M	3,38M	3,42M	3,48M	3,64M	3,81M
27. Arkhangelsk & Vologda Governorates	2,22M	2,28M	2,23M	2,17M	2,13M	2,14M	2,17M	2,28M	2,39M
28. Moscow Governorate	3,56M	3,82M	3,12M	2,78M	2,59M	2,76M	3,02M	3,58M	4,18M

29. Central Industrial Ring	11,52M	11,88M	11,42M	11,08M	10,82M	10,91M	11,08M	11,58M	12,12M
30. Western Central Black-Earth Governorates	7,98M	8,18M	7,98M	7,76M	7,56M	7,42M	7,36M	7,74M	8,18M
31. Eastern Central Black-Earth Governorates	9,22M	9,45M	9,21M	8,96M	8,71M	8,46M	8,34M	8,82M	9,38M
32. Middle Volga Governorates	8,35M	8,55M	8,28M	8,06M	7,86M	7,22M	6,78M	7,18M	7,64M
33. Samara & Saratov Governorates	6,88M	7,12M	6,98M	6,79M	6,58M	5,78M	5,18M	5,58M	6,02M
34. Astrakhan Governorate	1,38M	1,41M	1,36M	1,29M	1,22M	1,12M	1,05M	1,14M	1,24M
35. Province of the Don Cossack Host	3,88M	3,94M	3,81M	3,61M	3,38M	3,21M	3,09M	3,34M	3,62M
36. Kuban Oblast & Black Sea Governorate	3,06M	3,12M	3,04M	2,91M	2,74M	2,59M	2,49M	2,72M	2,98M
37. Stavropol Governorate & Terek Oblast	2,61M	2,65M	2,58M	2,48M	2,37M	2,29M	2,22M	2,39M	2,58M
38. Dagestan Oblast	715k	725k	695k	665k	645k	635k	620k	665k	710k
39. Perm & Vyatka Governorates	7,88M	8,04M	7,78M	7,49M	7,28M	6,98M	6,76M	7,16M	7,62M
40. Ufa & Orenburg Governorates	5,35M	5,48M	5,36M	5,16M	4,98M	4,38M	3,96M	4,29M	4,66M
41. West Siberian Trans-Siberian Belt	3,18M	3,32M	3,34M	3,26M	3,21M	3,17M	3,16M	3,42M	3,72M
42. Ob-Irtysh River Trail & Polar Tundra	505k	520k	515k	505k	495k	490k	495k	520k	550k
43. Tomsk & Altai	3,98M	4,18M	4,24M	4,19M	4,15M	4,19M	4,25M	4,56M	4,92M
44. Altai-Sayan Highlands	565k	575k	570k	560k	555k	560k	570k	600k	635k

45. Central Siberian Trans-Siberian Corridor	1,54M	1,56M	1,58M	1,56M	1,55M	1,57M	1,59M	1,72M	1,85M
46. Yenisei-Turukhansk Polar North & Bodaibo Lena Goldfields	270k	265k	260k	255k	250k	250k	250k	260k	270k
47. Transbaikal & Yakutsk Oblasts	1,29M	1,3M	1,29M	1,27M	1,25M	1,24M	1,25M	1,31M	1,39M
48. Priamurye, Amur & Sakhalin	1,14M	1,15M	1,18M	1,21M	1,21M	1,19M	1,17M	1,25M	1,3M
Subtotal Regs 25-48: Russia, Caucasus & Siberia	93,81M	96,58M	93,03M	89,56M	86,6M	83,75M	82,29M	88,04M	94,46M
Grand Total (All 48 Pre-War Regions)	167,94M	165,38M	160,6M	155,96M	152,04M	149,54M	148,66M	157,8M	167,78M

Table 1. Population of the 48 pre-war provinces at nine benchmark dates from 1914 to 1926, with subtotals for the Western Borderlands, Ukraine and the Russian-Siberian interior.

Keeping the pre-war borders fixed shows how the crisis moved from the western borderlands into the Russian interior. During the First World War and the Great Retreat (1914-1917), Regions 1-16 lost 5,12M inhabitants (falling from 41,91M to 36,78M, or 12,2%) as Russian armies evacuated or drove out civilians from Courland, Kovno, Grodno, Vilna, Congress Poland and Volhynia, while Austro-Russian fighting displaced hundreds of thousands in Eastern Galicia [8][34]. At the same time, Regions 25-48 gained 2,77M (rising from 93,81M to 96,58M, or 3%) as western refugees, evacuated Baltic and Polish factory workers and rear garrisons crowded into Petrograd, Moscow, the Central Industrial Ring, the Volga provinces and the Trans-Siberian railway towns.

During the Civil War, urban flight, epidemics and famine (1917-1922) reversed this pattern. Interior Russia and Ukraine were hit by multi-front fighting and the 1921-1922 harvest failure: Regions 25-48 fell by 14,29M (from 96,58M down to 82,29M in 1922, or 14,8%) and Ukraine (Regions 17-24) lost 3,73M (from 32,01M down to 28,28M, or 11,7%). Meanwhile, Polish, Baltic and Lithuanian refugees returned west after the 1918-1921 peace treaties, with Regions 1-16 reaching a low of 36,06M in 1919 before rising to 38,09M in 1922 and 41,43M in 1926.

By December 1926, Table 2 and Figure 3B show how the 167,78M inhabitants of the 48 pre-war provinces

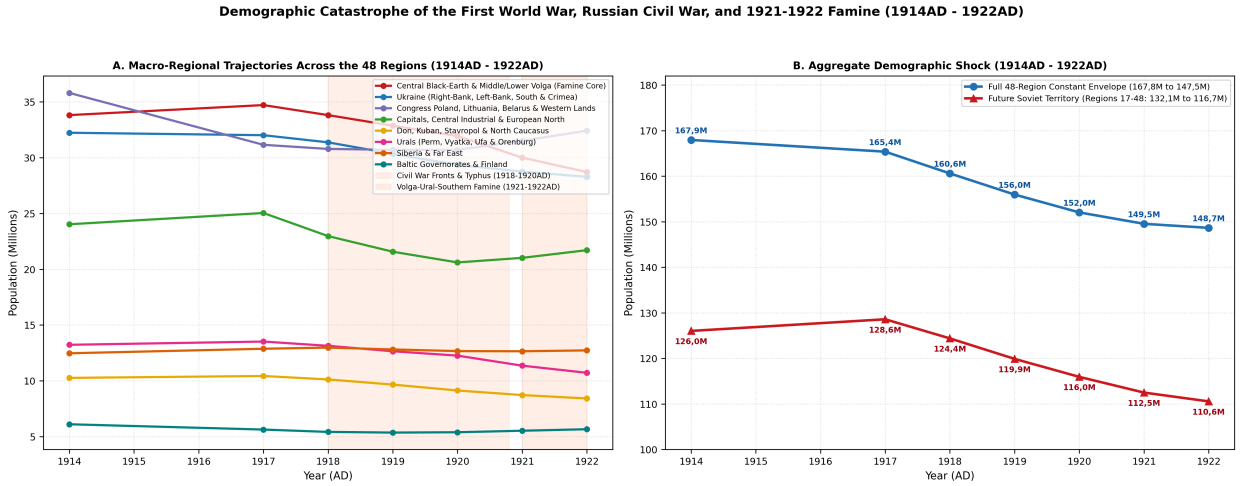


Figure 2. Relative population change by macro-region indexed to 1914 = 100 (Panel A) and absolute population totals in millions across the 48 pre-war provinces (Panel B).

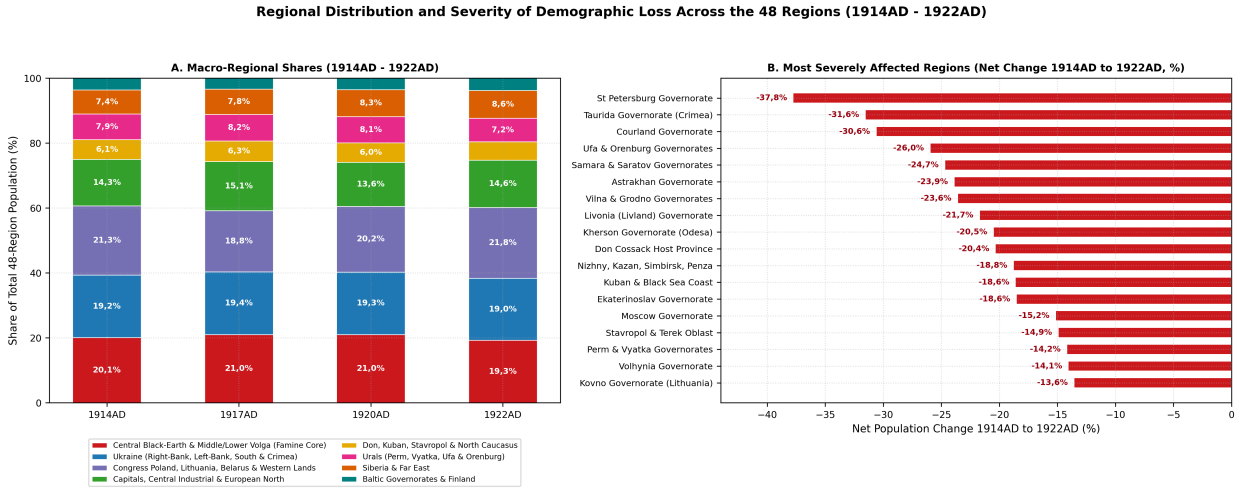


Figure 3. Provincial population losses from peak to Civil War trough (Panel A) and the 1926 partitioning of the 167,78M inhabitants between the USSR and seven European successor states (Panel B).

were divided between the interwar European states and the Soviet Union (145,07M in 1926 on post-1945 USSR borders). Peace treaties signed between 1917 and 1921 placed 37,84M people (22,6% of the 1926 total) inside seven Central and Eastern European states: Poland (24,61M), Romania (3,73M), Finland (3,6M), Lithuania (2,25M), Latvia (1,86M), Estonia (1,11M) and Czechoslovakia (670k). Internal Soviet border changes transferred 2,54M steppe inhabitants of Bukey (Astrakhan), southern Orenburg and southern Omsk districts into the Kazakh ASSR, 70k into Tannu-Tuva and 2,33M across western district adjustments, leaving 125M in the 1926 European and Siberian Soviet core (RSFSR and Karelia 92,41M, Ukraine and Crimea 27,75M and eastern Belarus 4,84M). Adding the 20,07M inhabitants (as of 1926) of the western lands later annexed by the USSR in 1939-1945 (Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Kaliningrad, Western Belarus, Western Ukraine, Northern Bukovina, Subcarpathia and Moldavia) gives the 145,07M baseline for 1926 on post-1945 Soviet borders.

1926 Territorial Component	Treaty / Instrument	1926 Pop.	Share
RSFSR European, Caucasian, Ural & Siberian Core (incl. Karelia)	1922 USSR Treaty / 1926 Census	92,41M	55,1%
Ukrainian SSR & Crimean ASSR (1926 All-Union Census Borders)	1922 USSR Treaty / 1926 Census	27,75M	16,5%
Belorussian SSR (1926 Enlarged Eastern Borders: Minsk, Vitebsk, Mogilev, Gomel)	1924 & 1926 BSSR Enlargements	4,84M	2,9%
Subtotal A: 1926 All-Union Soviet Census Core	17 Dec 1926 All-Union Census	125M	74,5%
Second Polish Republic (Congress Poland 13,83M + Riga Kresy 5,92M + E. Galicia 4,86M)	18 Mar 1921 Riga / 1923 Ambass.	24,61M	14,7%
Kingdom of Romania (Bessarabia 2,77M + Bukovina 960k)	Apr / Nov 1918 Union Acts	3,73M	2,2%
Republic of Finland (14 Oct 1920 Treaty of Tartu Borders)	14 Oct 1920 Treaty of Tartu	3,6M	2,1%
Republic of Lithuania (12 Jul 1920 Moscow Treaty + Klaipeda; excl. Polish Wilno)	12 Jul 1920 Moscow Treaty	2,25M	1,3%
Republic of Latvia (11 Aug 1920 Treaty of Riga: Courland, Vidzeme & Latgale)	11 Aug 1920 Treaty of Riga	1,86M	1,1%
Republic of Estonia (2 Feb 1920 Treaty of Tartu, incl. Narva & Pechory)	2 Feb 1920 Treaty of Tartu	1,11M	0,7%
Czechoslovak Republic (Subcarpathian Rus/Podkarpatska Rus, Trianon 1920)	1919 St-Germain / 1920 Trianon	670k	0,4%
Subtotal B: Detached into Seven Interwar Central-Eastern European States	1918-1923 Interwar Settlement	37,84M	22,6%
Transferred to Kazakh ASSR (Bukey, Orenburg & S. Omsk Steppe Uezds) & Tannu-Tuva (70k)	1920-1925 Kirghiz/Kazakh ASSR	2,61M	1,6%
Net Western Frontier & Governorate-to-Okrug Boundary Realignments	1920-1926 Admin. Delimitation	2,33M	1,4%
Grand Total on Fixed 48-Region Pre-War Footprint (1926)	48 Pre-War Provinces	167,78M	100%
Reconciliation to Post-1945 USSR Borders (1926): Subtotal A (125M) + 1939-45 Annexations (+20,07M)	Post-1945 USSR Splice	145,07M	-

Table 2. Distribution of the 167,78M inhabitants of the 48 pre-war provinces in December 1926 across the Soviet republics, the seven western successor states and post-1945 USSR borders.

Western Secession, Independence Wars and Refugee Repatriation

Former Congress Poland

Across the ten Vistula provinces of former Congress Poland (116,8k km2; Regions 1-4), the population fell by 2,02M (14,8%) between 1914 (13,65M) and 1917 (11,63M), reaching a low of 11,52M in 1918. Three shocks drove this decline: frontier fighting in August 1914 (when German shelling halved Kalisz from 65,4k to 29k), the Russian Great Retreat (*biezenstwo*) of summer 1915, which swept more than 1,2M people eastwards from Lublin, Siedlce, Kholm, Lomza and Suwalki (reducing Region 3 by 22,4%, from 2,68M to 2,08M), and raw-material blockades and labour requisitions under German and Austro-Hungarian occupation [8][27]. Cut off from Russian markets and imported cotton, the textile city of Lodz (Region 2) shrank from 477,9k in 1914 to 342k in 1917, while Warsaw (Region 1) fell from 884,5k to 758k. After the restoration of Polish independence in November 1918 and the Polish-Soviet War of 1919-1920, which peaked with Tukhachevsky's August 1920 advance on Warsaw and heavy typhus losses in prisoner-of-war camps [35], the Polish census of 30 September 1921 counted 12,32M across Regions 1-4 (Warsaw 936,7k, Lodz 452k and Lublin 94,4k) [26]. Repatriation trains operating under Article VII of the Treaty of Riga (18 March 1921) brought back more than 1,1M civilian refugees and former prisoners of war from Soviet Russia between 1921 and 1924, lifting Congress Poland above its pre-war level to 13,83M by 1926 (Warsaw 1,03M and Lodz 561,6k) [9].

Estland, Livland and Courland

Wartime evacuation and industrial dismantling were deepest in Courland (Region 7, 27,6k km2) and southern Livland (Region 6, 54,2k km2). When the German Niemen Army invaded Courland in spring and summer 1915, Russian military authorities and Latvian relief committees evacuated more than half the rural population and expelled the Jewish communities, cutting Courland's population by 52,5%, from 800k in 1914 to 380k in 1917 (Liepaja fell from 90,7k to 43,2k, Jelgava from 45,7k to 21,5k and Ventspils from 28,8k to 12,4k) [22][24]. Between 1915 and 1917 the authorities also dismantled 395 factories in Riga and evacuated roughly 300k metal, rubber and electrical workers with their families to Moscow, Petrograd, Kharkov and Ekaterinoslav; tens of thousands of displaced Latvian workers and farmhands joined the Latvian Riflemen (*Latviesu strelnieki*), later a mainstay of the early Red Army. After the Estonian and Latvian Wars of Independence (1918-1920), which included brief Soviet rule under Peteris Stucka, fighting against the Baltic German *Landeswehr* at Cesis in June 1919 and Pavel Bermondt-Avalov's autumn 1919 attack on Riga and Jelgava, the June 1920 Latvian census found only 185,1k inhabitants left in Riga, 64,2% below its 1914 peak of 517,5k [22]. Under the treaties of Tartu (2 February 1920 with Estonia) and Riga (11 August 1920 with Latvia), some 220k Latvian and 38k Estonian refugees returned from Soviet Russia. By the 1922 Estonian and 1925 Latvian censuses, Estland (Region 5) had reached 480k (498k in 1926, with Tallinn at 122,4k after losing its 1917 naval garrison peak of 159k), Livland stood at 1,33M in 1926 (Riga 339k and Tartu 50,3k) and Courland had recovered to 615k, still 23,1% below its 1914 total [21][22].

Southern and Northern Finland

Spared direct fighting during the First World War, Southern Finland (Region 8, 114,3k km2) and Interior and Northern Finland (Region 9, 263,8k km2) grew from 3,24M in 1914 to 3,32M in 1917 on the strength of Russian fortification work before being plunged into the short, bitter Finnish Civil War (27 January-15 May 1918) soon after independence [36][37]. Red Guards held the southern industrial towns (Helsingfors, Tammerfors, Kotka and Viipuri), while General Carl Gustaf Emil Mannerheim's White Senate raised peasant troops in Ostrobothnia and Karelia from Vasa and Sankt-Michel. Following the siege of Tammerfors in April 1918, the landing of the German Baltic Sea Division at Hanko and Helsingfors and the capture of Viipuri, the Finnish *War Victims (1914-1922)* register records 36,6k war-related deaths (out of an estimated total of 37k-38,5k, or more than 1,1% of the population in four months): roughly 9,6k killed in action, 1,65k in Red terror, 8,4k-10k in White summary executions and 12,5k-13,5k Red prisoners

(out of 80k internees) who died between June and September 1918 of hunger, dysentery and Spanish influenza in the camps at Tammisaari, Hameenlinna, Hennala, Suomenlinna and Viipuri [19][20]. Another 10k-12k Red Finns fled into Petrograd and Soviet Karelia, while Spanish influenza killed roughly 20k civilians across Finland in 1918-1919. The combined population dipped to 3,25M in 1918 (1,84M in Region 8 and 1,41M in Region 9) before steady peacetime growth carried Finland to 3,31M in 1920 and 3,6M in 1926 (Helsingfors 215,8k, Turku 61,8k, Tammerfors 52,4k and Viipuri 51,5k) [18].

Lithuania and Belarus

Across the four Northwestern provinces (304,8k km2; Regions 10-13), Russian evacuations in 1915 and three years of German *Ober Ost* requisitions (1915-1918) reduced Kovno (Region 10) by 28,3% (from 1,84M to 1,32M) and Vilna and Grodno (Region 11) by 26,9% (from 3,94M to 2,88M, and then to 2,76M in 1920 during Polish-Lithuanian-Soviet fighting, while Brest-Litovsk fell from 57,4k to 16,5k in 1917) [8][34]. After General Lucjan Zeligowski's October 1920 seizure of Vilna (which fell from 204,3k in 1914 to 128,5k in 1919 before recovering to 178k in 1926) and its incorporation into Poland in 1922, Kaunas became the provisional capital of Lithuania; its population rose from 42k in 1917 to 92,4k at the September 1923 census (94,4k in 1926) as 250k-300k Lithuanian refugees returned from Russia [23][25][34]. In Belarus (Minsk in Region 12, and Vitebsk and Mogilev in Region 13), the 1919-1920 Polish-Soviet war, Bulak-Balakhovich's Polesian raids and typhus reduced Minsk from 3,04M in 1914 to 2,68M in 1920 and Vitebsk-Mogilev from 4,02M to 3,61M (with Daugavpils falling from 112,8k to 31,5k by 1920 when Vitebsk's three Latgalian districts joined Latvia). The Treaty of Riga (18 March 1921) partitioned Belarus [28]: western Minsk (Pinsk, Baranovichi and Nowogrodek) and Grodno-Vilna went to Poland, while eastern Minsk formed the Belorussian SSR, which was enlarged in March 1924 and December 1926 by the addition of Vitebsk, Mogilev and Gomel (reaching 4,98M at the 1926 census; Minsk 131,8k, Vitebsk 98,9k and Gomel 86,4k) [38][39].

Eastern Galicia, Bukovina, Subcarpathia and Bessarabia

In former Austro-Hungarian Eastern Galicia (Region 14, 46,1k km2), repeated Russian and Austro-German offensives between 1914 and 1917 cut the population from 5,02M to 4,45M. The collapse of the Habsburg monarchy in November 1918 was followed by the Polish-Ukrainian War (November 1918-July 1919) over Lviv and the Drohobych-Boryslav oilfields, and then in summer 1920 by Semyon Budyonny's First Cavalry Army offensive; Region 14 dropped to a low of 4,29M in 1920 before recovering to 4,39M at the 1921 Polish census and 4,86M in 1926 [26][40][41]. In Region 15 (24,5k km2; 1,63M in 1914, 1,45M in 1920 and 1,63M in 1926), Bukovina (Czernowitz 102,8k in 1926) joined Romania in November 1918, while Subcarpathian Rus (Uzhhorod and Mukachevo) passed to Czechoslovakia under the treaties of Saint-Germain (1919) and Trianon (1920), recording 604,6k inhabitants in the February 1921 Czechoslovak census [29]. In Bessarabia (Region 16, 47,4k km2), Romanian military intervention in January 1918 and the *Sfatul Tarii* union vote of April 1918 cut the province off from Odessa and the Dniester grain trade. Border closures, refugee flight across the Dniester and three uprisings at Khotyn (January 1919, which drove roughly 50k refugees into Podolia), Bender (May 1919) and Tatarbunary (September 1924) reduced Bessarabia from 2,66M in 1914 to 2,52M in 1920 before rural natural increase restored the total to 2,77M by 1926 (though Kishinev remained below its 128,7k pre-war level at 115k), while Moscow set up the Moldavian ASSR (October 1924, with its first capital at Balta) on the left bank of the Dniester [30][31][42][43].

Ukraine, the Russian Interior, the 1921-1922 Famine and Siberia

Ukraine and the Southern Steppe

Ukraine (Regions 17-24, 541,9k km2; 32,23M in 1914 and 32,01M in 1917) was the main battlefield of the Civil War. Kyiv (falling from 644k in 1917 to 366,4k in 1920) changed hands more than a dozen times among the Central Rada, Pavlo Skoropadsky's Hetmanate, Symon Petliura's UNR Directory, the Red Army, Anton Denikin's Volunteer Army and the Polish-Ukrainian forces of May 1920 [44]. Across Right-Bank Ukraine (Volhynia in Region 17, Podolia in Region 18 and Kyiv in Region 19), the fighting of 1918-1920 brought the worst wave of anti-Jewish violence before the Second World War: more than 1,3k pogroms carried out by insurgent *atamans* (Grigoriev, Zeleny and Struk), Directory units, White regiments and retreating cavalry killed between 100k and 150k Jews, with major massacres at Proskurov (February 1919), Fastov (September 1919), Felshtin, Bila Tserkva, Uman, Cherkassy and Berdichev, and drove more than 500k survivors from ruined market towns into the larger cities or abroad [45][46][47].

Across the southern steppe (Kherson in Region 22, Ekaterinoslav in Region 23 and Taurida in Region 24), campaigning by Nestor Makhno's insurgent army around Huliaipole, Denikin's 1919 offensive towards Moscow and Pyotr Wrangel's 1920 Northern Taurida campaign wrecked the railway junctions and coal mines of Yuzovka, Lugansk, Krivoy Rog and Aleksandrovsk. In mid-November 1920, after the Red Army stormed the Perekop Isthmus, Wrangel evacuated 145,7k soldiers and civilians on 126 ships from Sevastopol, Yalta, Feodosiya, Evpatoriya and Kerch to Constantinople; the ensuing Red terror in Crimea under Bela Kun and Rozaliya Zemlyachka took another 50k-60k lives [7][48]. Severe drought in 1921-1922, worsened by continued grain shipments from southern Ukraine to northern Russia, then brought famine across the southern steppe and Crimea in 1921-1923, killing 300k-500k people around Zaporizhzhia, Ekaterinoslav, Nikolaev and Odessa (which fell by 55,2%, from 630k in 1914 to 282k in 1922) and another 100k in Crimea. Taurida fell by 32,2% (from 2,08M to 1,41M), Ekaterinoslav by 21,5% (from 3,58M to 2,81M) and Kherson by 21,2% (from 3,78M to 2,98M) before recovery under the NEP brought Regions 17-24 back to 31,89M in 1926, with Kharkov, the Ukrainian Soviet capital from 1919 to 1934, rising to 417,3k [44][49].

Petrograd, Moscow and the Central Black-Earth Belt

Figure 4 shows the sharp contraction of the major cities under War Communism recorded by the August 1920 census [16][17]. Cut off from Ukrainian coal, Baku oil and Siberian grain, and stripped of its government ministries when the capital moved to Moscow in March 1918, Petrograd (Region 25) lost 70,2% of its population in three years, dropping from 2,42M in 1917 to 1,47M in June 1918, 900k in 1919 (during Nikolai Yudenich's advance to the Pulkovo Heights) and 722,2k in August 1920; Saint Petersburg province as a whole fell by half, from 3,38M to 1,69M. Moscow (Region 28) fell by 49,1%, from 2,02M in September 1917 to 1,03M in August 1920 (with the province dropping from 3,82M to 2,59M), while the textile town of Ivanovo-Voznesensk (Region 29) fell by 60,4% (from 146k to 57,8k) as workers returned to their home villages [17][50]. Once the NEP restored private grain trade in March 1921 and reopened light industry, Moscow passed its pre-war peak to reach 1,54M in 1923 and 2,03M in December 1926 (province 4,18M), while Leningrad recovered to 1,07M in 1923 and 1,61M in 1926 (province 2,69M) [12][32].

In the European North (Region 27, which dipped from 2,28M in 1917 to 2,13M in 1920 before rising to 2,39M in 1926), British, American and French troops occupied Murmansk and Arkhangelsk from 1918 to 1920, and the Komi (Zyryan) Autonomous Oblast was formed around Ust-Sysolsk in August 1921. Across the Central Black-Earth Belt (Regions 30-31), Denikin's autumn 1919 offensive reached Kursk and Oryol (Region 30, which fell from 8,18M to 7,36M), while heavy grain requisitions (*prodrazvyorstka*) in Tambov and Voronezh (Region 31, down by 11,7% from 9,45M in 1917 to 8,34M in 1922) set off Aleksandr Antonov's 40k-strong peasant rebellion between August 1920 and summer 1921, which Mikhail Tukhachevsky suppressed with 100k Red Army troops, internment camps and village deportations [51][52][53].

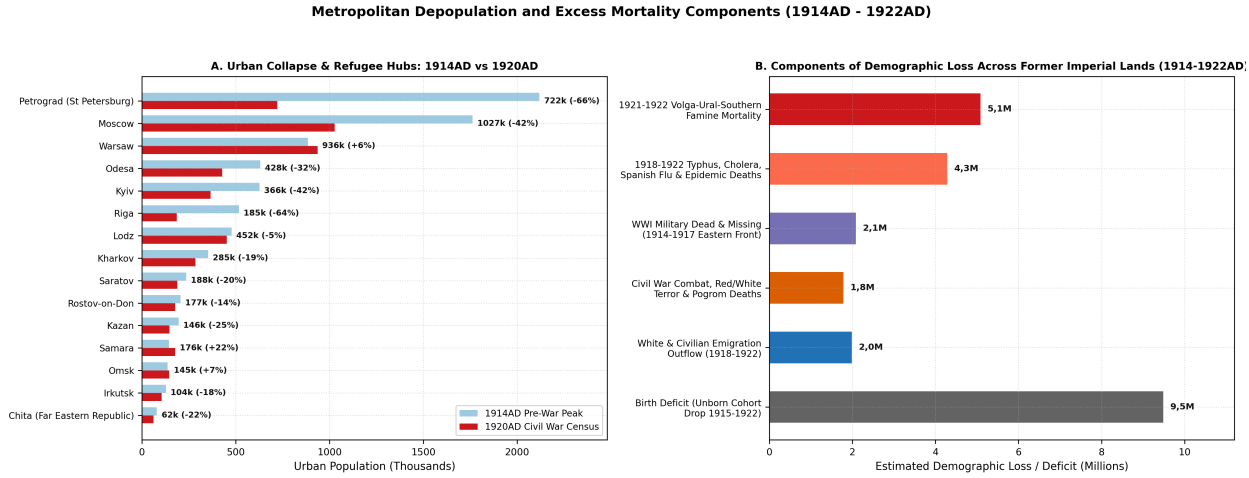


Figure 4. Populations of the 22 largest cities in 1914, at the height of War Communism in August 1920 and under the New Economic Policy in December 1926 (in thousands).

The Volga-Ural Famine and International Relief

The worst mortality crisis of the period struck the Volga-Kama-Ural basin (Regions 32-34 and 39-40, 1,44M km2) in 1921-1922. Three years of grain requisitions had exhausted peasant seed stocks across Samara, Saratov, Simbirsk, Kazan and Ufa just before the severe spring-summer drought of 1921 destroyed 60-85% of the harvest. Famine coincided with 25M-30M Soviet-wide cases of louse-borne typhus and relapsing fever (which caused 2,5M-3M deaths between 1918 and 1922), cholera along the Volga in 1921 and the Spanish influenza pandemic of 1918-1919 (1,5M-2M deaths) [54][55][56][57][58].

Along the Lower and Middle Volga steppe, Samara and Saratov (Region 33, including the Volga German autonomy) fell by 27,2%, from 7,12M in 1917 to 6,58M in 1920 and 5,18M in 1922, a loss of 1,94M; rural districts such as Pugachyov and Buzuluk and the Volga German settlements around Pokrovsk (Engels) and Marxstadt lost 25-35% of their inhabitants to starvation and flight before recovering partially to 6,02M in 1926 [59][60].

In the southern Urals, Ufa and Orenburg (Region 40, including the Bashkir ASSR) dropped by 27,7%, from 5,48M in 1917 to 3,96M in 1922 (a loss of 1,52M), before reaching 4,66M in 1926. Established in March 1919 as the first Soviet autonomous republic and expanded to include Ufa in June 1922, the Bashkir republic suffered losses of 25-30% in its rural cantons from famine and typhus, compounded by Aleksandr Dutov's 1918-1919 Orenburg Cossack campaigns and the transfer of southern Orenburg steppe districts to the Kazakh ASSR [61][62][63][64].

In the neighbouring forest-steppe provinces, Nizhny Novgorod, Kazan, Simbirsk and Penza (Region 32, including the Tatar ASSR and Chuvash AO established in 1920) declined by 20,7%, from 8,55M to 6,78M, with heavy mortality in Tatar and Chuvash villages. To the south, Astrakhan and the Kalmyk AO (Region 34) fell by 25,5%, from 1,41M to 1,05M [60][65], while in the Northern Urals, Perm and Vyatka (Region 39, including the Udmurt and Mari autonomous oblasts) fell by 15,9%, from 8,04M to 6,76M.

Following Maxim Gorky's international appeal in July 1921 and the Riga Agreement of August 1921, Herbert Hoover's American Relief Administration (ARA), Fridtjof Nansen's International Committee, the Quakers and the Soviet relief commission (*Pomgol*) opened kitchens and medical posts from Kazan to Orenburg and Odessa, feeding more than 10,5M people a day at their peak in August 1922 [66]. Table 3 compares estimates of 1918-1922 excess deaths across the main demographic studies, which attribute

roughly 5M deaths to the 1921-1922 famine within a total of 8M to 10,5M excess military, terror, epidemic and famine deaths, alongside 1,5M to 2M emigrants [1][3][5][10][11][55].

Demographic Study	Spatial Domain	1918-22 Excess Deaths	Key Finding
Volkov (1930) - TsSU Dynamic Series	USSR Interwar Borders	7M-8,5M	Documents 1920 urban collapse & 5M 1921-22 famine toll
Lorimer (1946) - League of Nations Balance	USSR 1926 Territory	9M-10M (incl. deficit)	14M+ total deficit incl. birth losses & 2M out-migration
Wheatcroft (1981) - Famine & Epidemic Study	USSR Famine & Epidemic Zones	5M (1921-22 Famine/ Typhus)	Isolates louse-borne typhus & Povolzhye-Ural harvest failure
Polyakov (1986) & Zhiromskaya (2000)	Soviet Territory (1917-1922)	8M-10M (+2M emigr.)	Integrates Civil War fronts, Red/White Terror & emigration
Maksudov (1989) - USSR Demographic Losses	USSR Territory (1918-1922)	7,8M-9,5M (+2M emigr.)	Separates combat/terror (2,5M), typhus (3M) & famine (4M-5M)
Andreev, Darsky & Kharkova (1993)	RSFSR & USSR Back-Projection	8,5M-10,5M (1921-22: 5M)	Age-sex cohort back-projection from 1926 All-Union Census
Present 48-Province Series (1914-1926)	48 Pre-War Provinces	9,5M-10,8M (+Finn./ Border)	167,94M (1914) to 148,66M (1922) to 167,78M (1926)

Table 3. Estimates of 1918-1922 excess deaths, famine mortality and net emigration across major demographic studies compared with the 48-province series.

The Don, Kuban and North Caucasus

Across the Cossack lands and the North Caucasus (Regions 35-38, 434,8k km2), Civil War fighting was accompanied by Soviet decossackisation (*raskazachivanie*) and the redrawing of highland borders [6][67][68].

In the Don Cossack Host (Region 35, which fell by 21,6% from 3,94M to 3,09M) and the Kuban-Black Sea region (Region 36, down by 20,2% from 3,12M to 2,49M), the early campaigns of Kaledin and Krasnov were followed in January 1919 by the Orgburo circular ordering terror against the upper-Don Cossacks. That order provoked the Veshenskaya uprising of March-June 1919, followed in turn by the winter 1919-1920 retreat across the Don and Kuban, the White evacuation from Novorossiysk in March 1920, Cossack deportations and the Salsk-Kuban drought of 1921-1922.

Farther east, in Stavropol and Terek (Region 37, down by 16,2% from 2,65M to 2,22M) and Dagestan (Region 38, down by 14,5% from 725k to 620k), heavy fighting between 1918 and 1920 pitted Terek Cossack settlements (*stanitsas*) against Chechen and Ingush highlanders, including the Hundred Days Battle of Grozny (August-November 1918). Between spring and autumn 1920, Sergo Ordzhonikidze ordered the deportation of 45k-70k Terek Cossacks along the Sunzha line and transferred their land to Chechen and Ingush settlers within the Mountain ASSR (proclaimed on 20 January 1921 with its capital at Vladikavkaz), which was divided between 1921 and 1924 into the Kabardino-Balkar, Karachay-Cherkess, Chechen, North Ossetian and Ingush autonomous oblasts while Grozny grew rapidly to 97,1k by 1926 on the strength of oil

recovery [62]. In Dagestan (proclaimed an ASSR on 20 January 1921, with its capital moved from Buynaksk to Makhachkala), Najmuddin Gotsinsky and Kailasan Alikhanov led the Avar-Andi mountain rising across Gunib and Khunzakh from September 1920 until its suppression by the 11th Red Army in May 1921.

Siberia and the Far East

Across Siberia and the Far East (Regions 41-48, 12,85M km2), total population stayed near or above its pre-war level (moving from 12,47M in 1914 to 12,88M in 1917, 12,66M in 1920, 12,73M in 1922 and 14,65M in 1926) because peasant flight from the famine-stricken Volga and Ural provinces offset local war and typhus losses [7][10].

In Western and Central Siberia (Regions 41-45), the revolt of the Czechoslovak Legion along the Trans-Siberian Railway in May 1918 allowed Admiral Aleksandr Kolchak to set up his White government in Omsk (Region 41), swelling the city with officials, soldiers and refugees from 148k in 1917 to roughly 245k in summer 1919. After Tukhachevsky's 5th Red Army took Omsk in November 1919, General Vladimir Kappel led the Great Siberian Ice March 2k km eastwards across Novonikolaevsk (Region 43), Taiga, Achinsk, Krasnoyarsk, Kansk and frozen Lake Baikal to Irkutsk (Region 45), where Kolchak was executed in February 1920; typhus along the railway killed tens of thousands of soldiers and civilians at Novonikolaevsk (which fell to 67,2k in August 1920 before growing to 120,1k by 1926 as the administrative centre of Siberia) and Krasnoyarsk (60,8k in 1920) [7]. From February to June 1921, grain requisitions around Ishim, Tobolsk, Kurgan and Tyumen provoked the 60k-strong West Siberian peasant rising, which cut both Trans-Siberian lines for three weeks [69][70]. Meanwhile, the agricultural districts of the Altai around Barnaul and Biysk (Region 43) took in hundreds of thousands of famine refugees, while in the Altai-Sayan highlands and Uriankhai (Region 44) Soviet authorities backed the creation of the Tannu-Tuva People's Republic in August 1921 alongside the Oyrot (Gorny Altai) AO and Khakass Okrug in 1922.

East of Lake Baikal (Regions 46-48), Moscow set up the Far Eastern Republic (April 1920-November 1922, with its capital at Chita) as a buffer state in Regions 47-48 to avoid open war with the 70k Japanese troops in the region while defeating Grigory Semyonov in Transbaikalia and Roman von Ungern-Sternberg along the Mongolian border [71]. In Yakutia (Region 47, proclaimed an ASSR in April 1922), the Yakut revolt of 1921-1923 and General Anatoly Pepelyaev's march from Ayan towards Amga in 1922-1923 closed the last White campaign in Russia shortly before the Aldan gold rush of 1924. In Priamurye and Sakhalin (Region 48), partisan commander Yakov Tryapitsyn burned Nikolaevsk-on-Amur in May 1920 (reducing the town to 3,2k), which served as the pretext for the Japanese occupation of Northern Sakhalin until 1925. Following the Red Army's Spassk offensive in October 1922, Japanese forces evacuated Vladivostok on 25 October 1922 alongside Admiral Georgy Stark's 30-ship White flotilla (carrying roughly 10k evacuees to Wonsan and Shanghai) and tens of thousands of refugees who crossed into Manchuria; the Far Eastern Republic was then absorbed into the RSFSR, and Vladivostok settled from its 1921 refugee peak of 136k to 108k in 1926 [72][73].

Conclusion

Across the twelve years between the outbreak of the First World War in 1914 and the All-Union Census of December 1926, the population of the 48 pre-war provinces returned almost exactly to its starting point, moving from 167,94M in 1914 and 165,38M in 1917 to 167,78M in 1926. That level outcome masks the sharpest demographic crisis in Russia's modern history before 1941: a drop to 148,66M in 1922 caused by 8M to 10,5M excess military, epidemic and famine deaths, roughly 2M emigrants and a large wartime birth deficit. By December 1926, border treaties and internal Soviet boundary changes had divided the pre-war territory between seven European successor states (37,84M), steppe district transfers to the Kazakh ASSR and Tannu-Tuva (4,94M) and the European and Siberian core of the RSFSR, Ukraine and Belarus (125M).

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